The Song of Hiawatha

A Reader's Companion Guide

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1855)

Epic narrative poem

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Spoiler tier: Full (the complete arc, including Minnehaha's death and the ending, is discussed)

Quick Take

The Song of Hiawatha is the poem behind the line everyone half-remembers: "By the shores of Gitche Gumee, by the shining Big-Sea-Water." Longfellow set out in 1855 to do for America what the Kalevala did for Finland and the King Arthur cycle did for Britain: write a national myth in verse. He mostly pulled it off as a cultural event. It was an instant bestseller, it taught a generation of white Americans how to picture Native people, and it spawned a century of pageants, films, and one genuinely great piece of choral music. Whether it is good poetry has been argued since the week it appeared. The rolling, drumbeat meter is hypnotic to some ears and absurd to others, which is why it became the most-parodied poem of its century. And modern readers have to reckon with a real problem at its core: it is a romanticized, secondhand, and factually scrambled portrait of Native life that frames Indigenous culture as gracefully fading away to make room for Christian Europeans. It is worth reading, but read it as a cultural artifact, not as ethnography. Read with the history in hand, it is fascinating; read it cold as fact and it misleads.

About the Author

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1807-1882) was born in Portland, Maine, taught modern languages at Bowdoin and then Harvard, and in 1854 resigned his Harvard chair to write full time. He was the most popular poet of his era and the central figure among the "Fireside Poets" (with Bryant, Whittier, Lowell, and Holmes), a group named for the way families read their work aloud by the fire. He was also the first American to fully translate Dante's Divine Comedy.

Hiawatha sits in the middle of Longfellow's run of book-length narrative poems built on American and legendary subjects: Evangeline (1847), his Acadian-exile epic and personal favorite; Hiawatha (1855); and The Courtship of Miles Standish (1858). The much-quoted "Paul Revere's Ride" came later, in Tales of a Wayside Inn (1860). Where Evangeline tells a European-American story, Hiawatha was his deliberate attempt to root a national mythology in Native legend, the most ambitious and most contested of his myth-of-America projects.

What the Critics Say

The poem split readers from the first week. Published November 10, 1855, by Ticknor and Fields, it sold roughly 50,000 copies by Longfellow's own 1857 accounting, a runaway success for an epic poem. One November 1855 observer captured the craze: "everybody writes trochaics, talks trochaics, and think[s] in trochees."

The reviews, though, were a brawl. The New York Times was scathing:

> *"...deserves no place" as poetry, the paper sniffed, insisting "there is no romance about the Indian."*

Defenders heard something the detractors missed. The critic John Neal called it

"a fountain overflowing night and day with natural rhythm,"

and George Eliot later ranked it among "the two most indigenous and masterly productions in American literature." Even the 1911 Encyclopaedia Britannica split the difference, conceding the meter is "monotonous and easily ridiculed, but it suits the subject." That tension, hypnotic versus monotonous, is the whole critical history of the poem in one sentence.

Two contemporary controversies are worth knowing. First, the parodies: the singsong rhythm was so catchy and so mockable that the Times reviewed a parody four days before it reviewed the actual poem. George A. Strong's "The Song of Milkanwatha" (1856) spoofed it canto by canto, and Lewis Carroll's "Hiawatha's Photographing" (1857) used the meter to narrate a family's disastrous attempt to pose for a portrait, prefacing it with a jab that the "easy running metre" could be churned out "for hours together." Second, the plagiarism charge: in November 1855 Professor Thomas Conrad Porter accused Longfellow of lifting the Kalevala. Longfellow defended himself in a letter to Charles Sumner, conceding he had borrowed the Finnish meter but denying he had stolen the legends, which he credited to Schoolcraft.

Modern criticism has shifted the conversation from meter to representation, and it is not gentle. Scholars read Hiawatha as the textbook "noble savage": critic Roy Harvey Pearce argued the poem "fully realized for mid-nineteenth century Americans the possibility" of that figure, a "purer, simpler, more childlike" Indian safely consigned to the past. The ending, in which Hiawatha cedes his place to arriving missionaries, is read as the "vanishing Indian" trope: it portrays Native culture as naturally dying out so that settlers could "rightfully move" into the space, a narrative that, intentionally or not, soothed American consciences about removal and displacement. Folklorist Stith Thompson noted that Longfellow gave his borrowed material "a unity the original will not warrant."

Themes and What Makes It Work

Nature is the spine of the poem. It appears in every one of the 22 cantos, sometimes as backdrop, often as plot engine, with personified winds, animals, and the Great Lakes (Gitche Gumee is Lake Superior) treated as characters. The poem's argument is that human beings live in dependence on and harmony with the natural world. That dependence is also the source of its tragedy: when famine comes, Hiawatha, who has conquered enemies and monsters, is powerless to save Minnehaha. Loss is the poem's emotional center, and Longfellow softens it, framing Minnehaha's death as a peaceful passage to a suffering-free afterlife and the arrival of Europeans as a benevolent handoff rather than a conquest. That gentle framing is precisely what makes the poem moving and what makes modern readers wince. The same scene works as elegy and as propaganda depending on what you bring to it.

The craft is inseparable from the controversy. The poem is written in unrhymed trochaic tetrameter, four falling beats per line, borrowed from the Finnish Kalevala, which produces a rolling, chant-like, almost drumbeat effect meant to evoke oral tribal song. Longfellow layered

on the Kalevala's structural parallelism and heavy repetition: refrains like "By the shores of Gitche Gumee" open cantos, and formulaic epithets recur throughout ("Laughing Water" for Minnehaha, "Big-Sea-Water" for the lake). Alliteration and relentless personification of natural forces complete the spell. Here is the engine in miniature, the opening that everyone knows:

> *By the shores of Gitche Gumee,*
> *By the shining Big-Sea-Water,*
> *Stood the wigwam of Nokomis,*
> *Daughter of the Moon, Nokomis.*

The repetition that critics called monotonous is exactly what lodges the lines in cultural memory. The meter is the poem's greatest strength and its greatest liability at the same time.

The Story (Full Spoilers)

The poem runs 22 cantos and moves from cosmic origin to heroic deeds to communal loss to a civilizational handoff.

Nokomis falls from the moon and bears a daughter, Wenonah. The West Wind, Mudjekeewis, fathers Hiawatha on Wenonah and then abandons her; she dies of grief, and Nokomis raises the boy. Hiawatha grows up, learns the truth of his mother's death, and confronts his father in a three-day battle, winning Mudjekeewis's respect rather than killing him. He fasts in the wilderness and wins the gift of corn (Mondamin) for his people, builds a canoe, and performs feats alongside the mighty strongman Kwasind and his gentle musician friend Chibiabos. He courts and marries the Dakota woman Minnehaha, "Laughing Water."

Then the losses begin. The boastful trickster Pau-Puk-Keewis wreaks havoc among the people and is eventually hunted down and destroyed. Kwasind, invulnerable except at the crown of his head, is killed by the jealous Little People (the Puk-Wudjies) who pelt his one weak spot with fir cones. Chibiabos dies and is mourned. A brutal winter brings famine and fever, and Minnehaha dies of hunger. Hiawatha's grief is the emotional climax of the poem.

In the final canto, white missionaries arrive by canoe. Hiawatha welcomes them, urges his people to listen to the Christian message they bring, and then departs alone, paddling westward into the sunset toward the Islands of the Blessed. The handoff is deliberate and peaceful, and it is the single most analyzed moment in the poem: depending on the reader, it is either a dignified ending or the clearest expression of the "vanishing Indian" myth in American literature.

What You Might Not Know

The hero is the wrong Hiawatha

This is the poem's central factual error. Longfellow's hero is essentially the Ojibwe culture-hero and trickster Nanabozho (Manabozho). Longfellow attached the name "Hiawatha" to him

because he mistakenly believed the two names were interchangeable. They are not. The real Hiawatha was a 16th-century Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) figure from what is now New York and Ontario who helped found the Iroquois Confederacy, the League of Five Nations. There is, as the Canadian Encyclopedia puts it, "virtually no connection, apart from name" between the two. Longfellow also blended Ojibwe and Dakota Sioux language and lore, collapsing distinct nations into a single generic "Indian."

The legends came secondhand, and partly from a woman who got no credit

Longfellow's primary source was ethnographer Henry Rowe Schoolcraft's Algic Researches (1839, later revised as The Myth of Hiawatha, 1856), supplemented by his friendship with the Ojibwe chief and author George Copway. Much of Schoolcraft's material had actually been researched and compiled by his Ojibwe-descended wife, Jane Johnston Schoolcraft, and her mother, work that went largely uncredited.

A foreign meter for an American myth

Longfellow studied Finnish during an 1835 summer in Sweden and consciously adopted the Kalevala's meter. So the poem that became the most "American" of myths is built on a Finnish skeleton, which is both a neat piece of literary cross-pollination and the basis of the plagiarism accusation.

The poem's greatest hit is a piece of music

The most consequential afterlife of Hiawatha is not literary or cinematic but musical. The Black British composer Samuel Coleridge-Taylor (whose father was from Sierra Leone) set the poem as a three-part cantata trilogy (1898-1900). "Hiawatha's Wedding Feast" premiered at the Royal College of Music in November 1898 and for a time rivaled Handel's Messiah and Mendelssohn's Elijah in British popularity; the vocal score sold around 140,000 copies before World War I. Coleridge-Taylor sold the copyright to Novello for about 500 pounds and never shared in the fortune the work earned, a famous injustice in music history. From 1924 to 1939, producer Thomas Fairbairn staged the trilogy at the Royal Albert Hall every year for a fortnight, with a real waterfall, a simulated snowstorm, a cast that grew to 1,000 performers, and a Mohawk medicine man (Chief Os-Ke-Non-Ton); George V and Queen Mary attended in 1928.

On Screen and Stage

Adaptations of Hiawatha trace a striking arc in how Native people were portrayed:

The 1909 Hiawatha (directed by William V. Ranous) was the first production of Carl Laemmle's IMP, the company that became Universal. It used white actors in bronze makeup and tacked on a happy ending. (A common misattribution credits this short to D.W. Griffith; there is no evidence he directed a Hiawatha film.) Just four years later, the 1913 Hiawatha (directed by Edgar Lewis) was the first film with an all-Native cast, starring Jesse Cornplanter (Seneca) and featuring roughly 150 Seneca performers from the Cattaraugus Reservation. It was co-presented

by the American Museum of Natural History and praised for its authenticity. The 1952 Hiawatha (directed by Kurt Neumann) swung back to a Cinecolor Western with non-Native leads.

Disney's Little Hiawatha (1937), a Silly Symphonies animated short, is the poem's pop-culture afterlife and the source of a sentimental, juvenile image of the figure that has little to do with Longfellow's epic.

The fullest modern screen version is the 1997 TV film Song of Hiawatha (directed by Jeffrey Shore), with a notable Native ensemble: Graham Greene, Litefoot, Irene Bedard, Russell Means, Adam Beach, and David Strathairn. It is reasonably faithful to the poem, though reviews were mixed, with several viewers describing it as feeling like a filmed community play despite some strong performances. It is the easiest way to watch the story (currently streaming on Tubi).

On stage, the poem sustained over a century of live pageantry. The Garden River First Nation near Wawa, Ontario, staged Anishinaabe-performed Hiawatha productions for railway and steamship tourists starting around 1899. The Song of Hiawatha Pageant in Pipestone, Minnesota ran annually for 60 years (1949-2008) with up to 200 volunteers; Life magazine covered it in 1952. Scholars now read the Indigenous-performed versions, especially Garden River, as acts of "Native space," Native communities performing the text on their own terms rather than as simple tourist kitsch.

If You Liked This

- **Evangeline (1847), Longfellow -** His other great American narrative poem; the natural next read for Longfellow's myth-of-America project, in sweeping dactylic hexameter rather than Hiawatha's trochees.
- **The Courtship of Miles Standish (1858), Longfellow -** Completes the trio of his most popular narrative poems; another verse retelling of early American legend.
- **The Kalevala (1835/1849), compiled by Elias Lonnrot -** The Finnish national epic whose meter Longfellow openly borrowed. Reading it explains exactly why Hiawatha sounds the way it does.
- **Idylls of the King (1859-1885), Tennyson -** The Victorian counterpart: a major poet spinning national legend into book-length verse for a mass audience.
- **Tracks or Love Medicine, Louise Erdrich (and Gerald Vizenor's work) -** Ojibwe/Anishinaabe authors offering an authentic, sovereign counterpoint to Longfellow's outsider portrait of the same culture.
- **Black Elk Speaks (1932), John G. Neihardt -** A Lakota holy man's life story; the inside view of Plains Native spirituality and the very "vanishing Indian" myth Longfellow helped build.

Companion and background reading

- **Henry Rowe Schoolcraft, Algic Researches (1839) / The Myth of Hiawatha (1856) -** Longfellow's direct source; note Jane Johnston Schoolcraft's largely uncredited role in compiling it.

- **Samuel Coleridge-Taylor's Hiawatha (Oxford Keynotes) -** The scholarly companion to the cantata phenomenon and its cultural-appropriation debates.
- **Anton Treuer, Everything You Wanted to Know About Indians But Were Afraid to Ask / Ojibwe in Minnesota -** For readers who want the real cultural picture behind the poem's romanticized Ojibwe world.

Listen and watch

- BBC Radio 3, Composer of the Week: Samuel Coleridge-Taylor (Donald Macleod, Nov 2022), plus a BBC Radio 3 program by Uchenna Ngwe on cultural appropriation and Native depiction in the cantatas.
- NPR feature on Coleridge-Taylor at 150 (Aug 2025).
- Note: there is no dedicated feature documentary about the poem itself; the strongest audio/video material centers on Coleridge-Taylor's music rather than Longfellow.

Book club discussion angles

- Authenticity and appropriation: a New England professor writing a Native epic from secondhand ethnography. Where is the line between homage and appropriation?
- The ending: is Hiawatha's departure a dignified farewell or the clearest "vanishing Indian" propaganda in American literature?
- The meter: does the trochaic drumbeat earn its hypnotic effect, or does it collapse into the singsong the parodists mocked?
- Source versus poem: what changed between Schoolcraft's Ojibwe material and Longfellow's unified narrative, and who got erased in the process (the real Iroquois Hiawatha, Jane Johnston Schoolcraft)?
- Reclamation: how do the Garden River pageants, and authors like Erdrich and Vizenor, answer or rewrite the story Longfellow told?

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